The process was further refined according to interest and specialization. If a boy or a girl showed potential in a specific field, whether it was gymnastics, hockey, football or athletics, we would send them to specially designated schools or areas where their talents could be further developed, like for example, Hoshiarpur, which specialized in football. There they could also participate in regular competitions and learn that healthy competitiveness went hand-in-hand with the spirit of sportsmanship. Our persistent efforts and zeal were rewarded and we produced several world-class sportspersons, including Ajit Pal Singh and Surjit Singh—both were students of the sports school in Jalandhar and later captained India in hockey; Balbir Singh Jr represented India in hockey; Ajaib Singh was the 400-metre champion and Mahinder Singh Gill, a triple jumper. Many of them participated in national-level games, and when they won they would be offered lucrative jobs by the railways, police, banks, and even corporate houses like Tata.

All my life, I have firmly believed that a strict training programme under the guidance of professional and competent coaches was the key to success, as well as will power and determination. Those were the principles that I stressed upon during the training period; they were, after all, the very mantras that I had lived by in my early years. I also believed that talent must be nurtured from a very young age for it to grow and flourish. If I hadn’t received the support and encouragement from the army when I was starting off, would I have reached the heights that I did?

During the summer vacations in May and June, the department held month-long summer camps in picturesque hill stations such as Srinagar, Simla, Manali, among others. We would book a stadium that had all sports facilities, and organize accommodation and make arrangements for food for almost five hundred boys and girls. The camps adhered to a strict schedule, beginning the day with prayers and a roll call. Thereafter, the time was spent on the field. The weather, fortunately, was cool and pleasant, so being outdoors was always invigorating. My role in the camps was to inspire and motivate each and every child and to convince them that the road to fame was not a bed of roses, that only hard work, dedication, will power and discipline would lead them to their destiny. I would tell them about my early life, about the relentless training schedules I had set for myself, about the toil and perseverance, all because of my overpowering desire to succeed in international events. Because I was so obsessed with training, I would